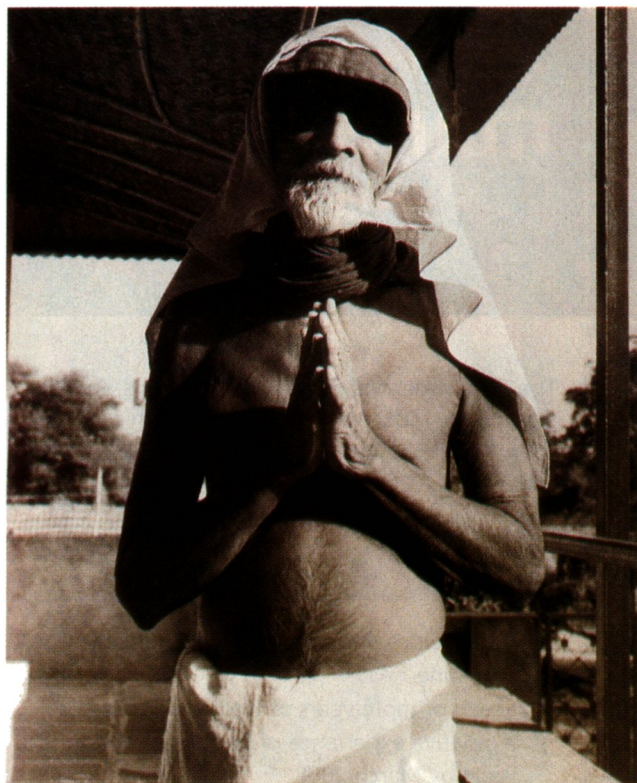




ON VINOBA BHAVE

There was a foolish man, Vinoba Bhave, who in the early 1950s tried to do a Gandhi repeat. He had been brought up in Gandhi's various ashrams. The mental idleness of those places had softened his brain and entered what might be called his soul. He worked in the kitchen and did the latrines and then sat for so long at his spinning wheel that Gandhi noticed and worried about it. He thought that Vinoba, who was still a young man, should go away and study somewhere. If he didn't he was going to fall ill at the ashram spinning wheel. Vinoba went to the holy city of Banaras, and there he was thought by the devout to have developed fantastic yogic powers.

He had lived for so long as a parasite, and away from the world, that he had become a kind of half-man, and he thought that Gandhi had been like that too...

There was, happily, a later career for Vinoba, not as a reformer, not as a wise man, but as a kind of holy fool, someone politicians at the very top wished to be photographed with and whose blessing they wished to have....

Not many years ago an Indian woman parliamentarian, concerned about Indian cruelty to animals (as Gandhi had been, though only in passing), said that people should stop drinking cow's milk; the animals were dreadfully tormented to produce milk. The newspapers ridiculed the parliamentarian; there were cartoons. But what she was saying was only what Gandhi had said seventy years before. Gandhi drank goat's milk; this was generally known; what wasn't known, or had been forgotten almost as soon as it had been said, was why he didn't drink cow's milk. Gandhi also spoke about the peasant's cruelty towards his bullocks. But this again is something no one in India remembers.

The saintly half-clad figure Aldous Huxley saw on the rostrum in Kanpur in 1925 was not wholly Indian, as Huxley thought. The best part of Gandhi in 1925 had really been in London and South Africa. And just twenty-five years later he would be out of date, the various pieces of his thought irrecoverable.

India has no autonomous intellectual life. Of the many millions whom independence has liberated a fair proportion now look away from India for ultimate fulfilment. They look in the main to Britain and the United States. They look especially to the United States. Immigration rules have changed; but the place is still not crowded out with Indians. That is where the better jobs are, where Indians are well thought of, and that is where people of a certain level wish to live and marry—and make cookies and shovel snow off the pavement in winter—and educate their children.

As much as Chaudhuri did (though he kept it quiet, almost until the end), they wish to shake India off, shake off what they see as the retarded native element in dhotis and caste-marks, temple-goers, to use a kind of shorthand, bad at English, and as an element getting bigger and politically more dangerous by the year. In their new setting the people who have got away wish to dress more stylishly. They wish to wear their own contemporary equivalent of Chaudhuri's regency gear. It is their solution to the problem of India, which is really the problem they have with India.

Out of India's improved English education there has come a crop of novels—a fair number are also by Indian expatriates, mainly from the United States—and there is a new one almost every month. These novels are by and large autobiographical. Every Indian who looks within himself finds the matter for a family story, with great characters, *daddyji* and *mamaji* and *nanee* and *chacha*, against a background of the extended Indian family. Since no writer can have two extended families, these novels appear to be rationed, one per writer. One writer, one book: it may not build a literature, but it is a system that allows new writers and new families to come up all the time.

Is this writing just old-fashioned Indian boasting? Or are these books to be seen as part of a new Indian literary awakening, matching Bengal's of a hundred years ago, helping India now to understand its more complicated self, to develop an autonomous cultural life, to bridge the gap